

My name is Naprey Almario, 37 years old from Davao city, a PWD (Persons with Disability) advocate, an entrepreneur, and a person in a wheelchair. I was actually born healthy and was able to experience the pleasure of childhood. Like any other kid in their early years, I enjoyed a lot of walking, running, and jumping. I enjoyed dancing as well. In fact, in school, I always joined events that required dancing. I was once a very active kid.

But life played a hard trick on me at a very young age of eight. I was diagnosed with polio, an illness that affects the nerves. It can be prevented, but no cure. I had to stop schooling because of polio. I was admitted to different hospitals, and for almost one year, I immersed myself in therapy, hoping for recovery. During the time I was in the hospital, I can vividly recall how my family and I were so anxious when the doctor delivered it straight to my parents that both of my lower extremities were paralyzed. I urged my feet again and again for some movement. I struggled to move it around, but to no avail; it remained limp and motionless.

The faint memories of the paralysis that crept its way to my legs sharply remind me of the challenges I had to face growing up. The kid who used to running around, playful, suddenly becomes limited and stuck in a wheelchair. At times, I questioned myself. I questioned my parents, and I even questioned God. I thought that I had done nothing wrong that merited this kind of illness (polio). It was really tough until I decided it shouldn't be. With my eyes closed, hands on my wheels, and heart hopeful, I slowly started overcoming all fears, including the harsh reality that I can no longer walk. Will my disability hinder me from pursuing my dreams?

I started dreaming, making dreams, and chasing them with my wheels. I realized there is more to life than just walking, running, and jumping. I went to college and graduated with a BS in Information Technology. I was given a leadership award during graduation, and I also gave a graduation speech. Luckily, I was hired by my school as a college instructor, and that was my first job after college. I then took up my master's while I was teaching.

I thought I had everything that I needed. I have a career, and I earn my own money. But something is missing. A piece of my life is not happy. I thought that the missing piece is the purpose of giving back and serving the PWD sector (Persons with Disability). I joined an organization called the Association of Differently Abled Persons, where I was taught to lead the group as well. Joining the group has taught me to champion for the people living with disability like me, create awareness, and really help those PWDs who are struggling as well.

I transformed my disability into something else. I turned it into a blessing, a chance to inspire and be inspired. I started an advocacy that provided a platform to promote accessibility by establishing "Behind the Rolling Chair". This allowed me to share my story and to rally all those who support my cause, that as PWDS, we can turn our disability into abilities, that we are not limited but limitless, and that we are not stuck but soaring. My legs may not be able to walk, but I have hands that can reach out and make a difference, coupled with a determined heart.

I started the Back to School Gift Giving Project through Behind the Rolling Chair. We went to different far-flung areas to distribute school supplies to underprivileged students including SPED schools and orphanage. We partnered with other groups and companies to reach out to thousands of students who need school materials.

Aside from the Back to School project, I continuously championed the PWD sector by promoting and creating awareness about accessibility and inclusion. I joined the famous TV reality show, Pinoy Big Brother (Unlimited), to show the public that we can also do more as PWDs. I also starred in an airline commercial to promote accessible travel. Together with

fellow advocates, we also trained a lot of PWDs on remote working through the help of Google Group.

Little by little, I also ventured into business. I opened my travel agency that specifically promotes accessible tourism. I get to travel the world because of what I do as a travel agent. When my travel agency business was at a standstill during the pandemic, I opened a Bills Payment Center through Cebuana Lhuillier. Luckily, I survived the pandemic and hired people with disabilities as well, who lost their jobs during the pandemic. We were consistently among the top Cebuana Lhuillier agents in Davao Region (Top 1 for 2025 1st Qtr) since we opened the business up to the present.

Because of my advocacy for the PWD sector also, I was fortunate to be awarded an Australia Awards Scholarship. In 2016, I flew to Australia to study for a master's degree under the Australian Government's full scholarship. I got to experience a different life of someone in a wheelchair in a barrier-free environment. I learned many things, not just academically, but as a whole.

I returned to the country after my study abroad to continue making a difference and giving back to my community. I was selected to join the Regional Development Council (RDC) as a private sector representative for the PWD sector. I represented the country in different disability gatherings here and abroad. And I am continuously fighting for the rights of the PWD sector. This is now my life's purpose.

And with everything happening in the world right now, I am in a place where great things are bound to happen. My life experience taught me to always push forward and celebrate life. Life is a matter of how you face any challenge. The key is just to never stop and to keep going. With courage, faith, and determination, we can all walk, run, jump, and even on wheels. Let's continue to move forward with purpose in life.